



A WORLD CUP REBORN

The 2026 edition promises the **broadest canvas** yet for football's universal dream.

Neeladri Bhattacharjee
neeladri.b@thehindu.co.in

For nearly a century, the grand narrative of FIFA World Cup participation has been shaped most heavily by its two dominant continents, Europe and South America. Out of the eighty countries that have played in the World Cup so far, 34 have been from Europe and 10 from South America. This glass ceiling looks set to crack in the 2026 edition, where the number of participating teams has been expanded from 32 to 48. As a result, the combined share of European and South American teams will fall below 50 per cent for the first time ever in the history of the tournament.

"We're in the 21st century, and we have to shape the World Cup for the 21st century. We have to look at football as more than just Europe and South America," FIFA president Gianni Infantino had said.

A moment in the sun for Africa

Africa, one of the biggest beneficiaries of the expansion, had called the disparity in representation at the World Cup "pathetic" before boycotting the 1966 edition.

The single combined slot for Asia, Africa and Oceania in 1966 has now grown to a cumulative 18 in the 2026 edition, the largest yet. It could rise to 20 if Iraq, Congo or New Caledonia qualify through the inter-confederation play-offs.

Over the years, Africa has proved

to be a potent contender in global football despite receiving limited World Cup slots, with Morocco finishing fourth in the most recent edition.

From North America, there will be at least nine teams, including debutant Cape Verde. A tiny archipelago off the coast of West Africa, it beat Eswatini to become the second-smallest country by land area and the third-least populous nation to qualify.

There could be another tale of renaissance from Africa — that of the Democratic Republic of Congo. Formerly known as Zaire, the country last appeared in the 1974 World Cup — a stint marred by player-bonus disputes and threats made to players after a poor showing in the finals.